

A center of philosophy

As well as being the most powerful city-state in ancient Greece, Athens was also the crucible of a revolutionary new direction in philosophy, in large part due to Socrates (c. 469–399 BCE). Earlier Greek philosophers, collectively known as the pre-Socratics, had introduced a revolution of their own in human thought in the 5th and 6th centuries BCE. They rejected supernatural explanations for the world, the explanatory power of mythology, and the authority of tradition, and set out to discover the origins and workings of the natural world through reason and observation. The pre-Socratic natural philosophers developed theories about the elements, classifications of nature, and mathematical and geometric proofs.

Socrates turned his inquiries inward to more human matters—as Cicero said of him, “he brought philosophy down from heaven.” Socrates’ method was simply to ask questions—What is friendship? What is justice? What is knowledge? The Socratic method tended to lay bare the limits of existing thinking, often making people look foolish or pompous. Accordingly, Socrates was unpopular and eventually he was accused of two crimes by his enemies—corrupting youth by encouraging them to go against the government, and impiety, or lack of respect for the gods. Consequently, he was sentenced to death.

Socrates' successors

The fate of Socrates was taken as an indictment of democracy by his successors, particularly Plato (c. 428–348 BCE), who saw him as a martyr for truth. Plato ran a school (the Academy) and developed ideas about universal truths and metaphysics that have shaped all subsequent religion and philosophy in the Western world. His student Aristotle (384–322 BCE) became equally influential, setting up the Lyceum school and writing on such diverse topics as politics, ethics, law, and natural sciences.

Plato opposed democracy, because he believed that the people were not sufficiently equipped with philosophical grace to legislate, and if governance were left in the hands of the ordinary citizen



An Audience in Athens (1884), by Sir William Blake, captures the atmosphere at the Greek tragedy *Agamemnon* by Aeschylus c. 450 BCE. This period is regarded as the Golden Age of drama in ancient Greece.

tyranny would emerge. In his ideal republic, enlightened philosophers would rule as kings. He also challenged the basic principle of democracy—that of liberty (*eleutheria*)—which he believed could divert people from the proper pursuit of ethics and cause social disunity.

The fall of democracy

During the Peloponnesian War (431–404 BCE), in which Athens was ultimately defeated by the Spartans, Athenian democracy was twice suspended, in 411 and 404 BCE. Athenian oligarchs claimed that Athens’ weak position was due to democracy and led a counterrevolution to replace democratic rule with an extreme oligarchy. In both cases, democratic rule was restored within one year.

Democracy flourished for the next eight decades. However, after the Macedonian conquest of Athens under Philip II and his son Alexander (later Alexander the Great) in 322 BCE, Athenian democracy was abolished. It was intermittently restored in the Hellenistic age in the 1st and 2nd centuries BCE, but the Roman conquest of Greece in 146 BCE effectively killed it off.

Although democratic rule had been quashed, Athenian science and philosophy lived on. The renown and influence of Plato and Aristotle endured through the ages that followed, and much of their work continues to influence Western thought to this day. ■